

DELHI DETOUR The Naidu parivar with PM Modi, June 2025

ANI

THE CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **As Lokesh steps out of father Naidu's shadow, securing the undisputed loyalty of senior leaders and the party cadre is crucial**
- **Managing frictions with NDA partners Jana Sena and BJP is a must to ensure a cohesive front in 2029 against Jagan's YSR Congress Party**
- **Has projected himself as job creator-in-chief, and now must deliver on the promise**
- **Inflation, power tariffs and rural welfare will be key poll issues in 2029. Lokesh will be targeted if they are not managed well**
- **Completing the Amaravati capital city project and Polavaram irrigation project crucial to bolster his 'development man' image**

2025, the party claimed its membership had crossed the 10 million mark, an achievement widely credited to Lokesh, who oversaw the tech-driven enrolment drive and its seamless registration process. This is a big improvement of 52 per cent from the last time the drive was conducted in 2018—when 6.6 million members were enrolled—and is almost two-thirds of the votes the TDP got in 2024.

Meanwhile, partymen expect Naidu to hand over the state's reins to Lokesh soon. While a section of TDP leaders links the coronation to Naidu moving to the Centre, "if he is offered something suitable to his stature, perhaps the deputy PM's post ..." others feel he will stay on in AP to mentor Lokesh for the 2029 assembly election. The TDP scion, though, deflects any such speculation. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Lokesh says his hands are full. "Our leader (Naidu) has given us a lot of work to build the state. I am not focused on roles but more on my responsibilities."

IN JAN. 2025, THE TDP MEMBERSHIP TOUCHED 10 MILLION. LOKESH HAD HEADED THE TECH-DRIVEN ENROLMENT AND SEAMLESS REGISTRATION

THE TASK AHEAD

The post of TDP national working president, which Naidu has bestowed on Lokesh, is the first such for the 44-year-old party. However, even though he wields much influence over state administration matters, coming out of his father's shadow and establishing an independent identity will not be easy for Lokesh. According to sources, his first electoral challenge will be the local body polls due later this year. The TDP has the advantage as the ruling party, but the opposition YSRCP is expected to give a tough fight, especially in rural AP, an area where Lokesh needs to project himself as a mass leader.

And while the TDP scion says he wants to be known as 'job creator-in-chief', he faces a big hurdle in a state that lacks a major growth engine, such as tech hub Hyderabad in neighbouring Telangana (Vizag is still in a nascent stage in comparison). One of the TDP alliance's pre-poll Super Six promises was to create 2 million jobs for skilled youth. The YSRCP is also taking the government to task over its 2025 LIFT policy, which in the rush to attract investment is allocating land at 99 paise per acre in prime city centres like Vizag to tech giants. A controversy erupted last year over such a land allocation to an allegedly obscure firm.

Meanwhile, the newly reconstituted party committees have Lokesh's imprint all over—close companions like Rajesh Kilaru and K. Rammohan Naidu are now the party's national general secretaries. Some seniors have been sidelined in the bargain, and how he manages the situation going forward will be closely watched.

The young leader's frequent trips to Delhi to meet BJP leaders and central ministers are also being seen as attempts to strengthen his case if and when Naidu decides to hang up his boots or accepts a position at the Centre. Within the state, the response from the JSP and current deputy CM Kalyan will be of interest, for the popular actor-neta is said to harbour ambitions of assuming the top post himself.

How the TDP scion navigates all this will determine the next chapter of his political career. D.A.R. Subramanyam, chairman of the Navyandhra Intellectual Forum, says, "If Lokesh is made CM by mid-2027, it would give him two years on the job, enough time to shore up his credentials for the battle against Jagan." Despite the drubbing in 2024, the YSRCP leader still commands a 40 per cent vote share and remains hugely popular. Taking him on will be the ultimate political test for Nara Lokesh. ■